

University of Professional Studies, Accra

Department of Communication Studies

BACS 102 / Introduction to Journalism / Week 4

News Gathering and Reporting

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Presentation Outline

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Traditional News Gathering Approaches

Observation, Documents & reports, beat journalism & physical events

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By the end of this week, students should be able to:

- 1 Describe the traditional and digital methods journalists use to gather news.
- 2 Explain how internet and social media, citizen journalism, multimedia platforms, and open data are used to gather news.
- 3 Identify major interview types and demonstrate sound preparation, technique, and ethical conduct.
- 4 Explain the principles of source management, including diversity, reliability, and protection.
- 5 Outline the methods and challenges of investigative journalism.
- 6 Apply verification and fact-checking standards guided by sound ethical judgement.

Traditional News Gathering Approaches



Traditional Approaches

“Get out of the office and go talk to people.” — attributed to veteran wire-service reporters, on the value of shoe-leather journalism

Core Methods

Direct observation places the reporter at the scene, whether a market fire in Kaneshie or a parliamentary sitting, to record what is seen, heard, and felt firsthand, producing detail no secondhand account can match.

Records and documents, including court filings, budgets, gazettes, and official reports, give reporters a verifiable paper trail; press conferences and beats, meanwhile, provide scheduled and ongoing access to institutions, sources, and breaking announcements.

Traditional Methods

Method Snapshot: Traditional reporting blends direct observation, documentary evidence, and institutional access to build a verified account of events.

Traditional News Gathering Approaches

Observation: Reporters attend the scene in person i.e a demonstration, a rally, a court sitting etc to capture detail, atmosphere, and firsthand accuracy.

Records & Documents: Gazettes, budgets, contracts, and court filings anchor a story in verifiable paper evidence.

Physical Events: Journalists are usually invited to cover events such as press conferences, product launch, graduation, speech day, commissioning of projects, donations, workshops/seminars, etc. They receive invitation letters that contains the date of the event, venue, time and organizers as well as a brief about the event.

Beat Journalism/Specialized reporting: A reporter's regular specialized area of reporting, i.e health, gender, politics, courts, climate change etc. Familiarity builds the sources that break stories.

Modern & Digital News Gathering

Internet, social media, and open data

Modern & Digital Newsgathering Approaches

Internet & Social Media

Social platforms, forums, and comment sections surface breaking news, eyewitness accounts, and public sentiment in real time.

Multimedia & Multi-Platform Storytelling

A single story now needs to work as text, video, audio, and graphics across platforms. Example: Multimedia Ghana Ltd (Joy FM, JoyNews, Adom FM, myjoyonline.com), Media General (TV3, Onua FM, 3news.com) etc.

Citizen Journalism & User-Generated Content

Ordinary people with smartphones often capture the first images or footage of a breaking event.

Open-Source & Data Journalism

Public records, datasets, and open-source tools help reporters verify claims and uncover patterns in numbers.

Interviewing Skills



Getting the story straight from the source

Types of Interviews

Interviews are shaped as much by their format as by their purpose.

Structured. A fixed set of questions asked in the same order, rigid, useful for consistency and comparing responses across sources. Usually used for high profile /individuals such as Presidents, Ministers etc

Unstructured. A free-flowing conversation with no fixed question list, letting the interviewer follow the subject's answers. This type is used for *in-depth features, senior officials, opinion pieces*

Semi-structured. A core set of guiding questions with room for follow-up, the most common format in journalism.

One-on-one. A single interviewer and a single subject, allowing depth, rapport, and sustained follow-up. This type is used during *Investigations by security agencies, job interviews, whistleblower interviews*

Panel. Several interviewers questioning one subject or panel, common in press conferences and high-stakes settings. Examples are *Press conferences, parliamentary hearings, live media events*

Quick Comparison: How Interview types differ

Interview Type	Setup	Flow	Rapport	Comparison	Bias	Time
Structured	Fixed	Linear	Formal	Easy	Low	Faster
Unstructured	Open	Organic	High	Hard	High	Longer
Semi-Structured	Guide	Guided	Good	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate
Panel	Formal	Observed	Formal	Easy	Low	Fixed
One-on-One	Intimate	Natural	High	Varies	Varies	Flexible

Application:

Choose your interview type based on whether you need comparison (structured), depth (unstructured), or balance (semi-structured). Most professional journalism uses semi-structured interviews.

Before, During, and After the Interview



Research the Subject

Know their background, prior statements, and the specific facts you need confirmed before you sit down.



Plan Your Questions

Draft open-ended questions in a logical order, but stay ready to follow an unexpected answer.



Build Rapport

A few minutes of genuine conversation earns trust and often the most candid answers.



Listen Actively

The best follow-up question usually comes from what the source just said, not your notebook.



Ask the Hard Question

Save sensitive or confrontational questions for later, once trust is established.



Record and Verify

Take notes or record with consent, and confirm names, titles, and quotes before you leave.

Interview Ethics

Informed Consent

Sources should understand who you are, what outlet you represent, and how their words may be used.

Vulnerable Sources

Extra care and sensitivity are required when interviewing children, victims, or trauma survivors.

On/Off the Record

Agree ground rules for attribution before the interview starts, not after a sensitive answer.

Right of Reply

Give subjects of criticism a fair opportunity to respond before publication.

Source Management



Protecting who tells you the truth

Named vs. Anonymous Sources

Two kinds of sources, two different obligations

Every story rests on sources. How you handle them shapes both credibility and safety.

Named / On-the-Record

Leads with: full attribution, name, and title.

Top values: accountability and transparency.

Strengthens credibility, but sources may fear retaliation for speaking openly.

Anonymous / Protected

Leads with: information the public needs but a named source cannot safely give.

Top values: protecting the source.

Requires corroboration; used only when justified and approved editorially.

Reliability and diversity of sources must always be checked, whichever kind you use.

Investigative Journalism



Digging beneath the press release

How Investigations are built



Follow the Paper Trail

Contracts, procurement records, and financial filings often reveal what officials will not say aloud.



Map Relationships

Understanding who owns, funds, or influences an institution exposes conflicts of interest.



Track the Money

Budgets, audits, and expenditure reports expose corruption and mismanagement.



Use Data & FOI Requests

Freedom-of-information requests and open datasets can surface what sources will not confirm.



Corroborate Everything

No single claim runs on one source alone; investigations need multiple independent confirmations.



Protect the Story

Careful timing, legal review, and source protection guard the investigation until it is ready.

Verification & Ethics



Getting it right before getting it out



Verification, Fact-Checking, and Ethics in Practice

Speed without verification is how newsrooms get it wrong and lose trust.

Confirm before you publish. Two independent sources or documentary evidence should back any contested claim.

Separate fact from claim. Report what a source alleges as an allegation, not as established fact, until verified.

Protect vulnerable sources. Anonymity and safety come before a dramatic quote.

Disclose conflicts of interest. Declare gifts, relationships, or affiliations that could compromise your reporting.

Correct errors transparently. A prompt, visible correction protects both the audience and the newsroom's credibility.

Class Discussion

Think. Discuss. Disagree.

In groups of 3–4, spend 10 minutes. One person reports back to the class.

Q1

You're covering a protest. What traditional and digital techniques would you use to gather accurate information on the ground?

Q2

A source will only talk if you promise anonymity. How do you decide whether to agree, and what do you do next?

Q3

How might OSINT tools help, or mislead, a Ghanaian newsroom verifying a viral video?

Q4

An investigation is nearly ready, but one source could face retaliation if named. What do you do before publishing?

Key Takeaways from Week 4

Traditional methods still matter. Observation, records, press conferences, and beats remain the foundation of reliable reporting.

Modern & Digital Approach extends your reach. Digital tools let you verify claims and locate information without leaving the newsroom.

Preparation makes the interview. Research, planned questions, and active listening produce the strongest material.

Sources deserve protection. Diversity, reliability, and safety must guide every source relationship.

Investigation demands patience. Documents, data, and corroboration build a story that can withstand scrutiny.

Verify before you publish. Ethical, fact-checked reporting is what separates journalism from rumour.

Any questions or comments?

Thank you.